

Transforming primary care through advanced practice nursing

The Comment by Abdulqadir Nashwan published in *The Lancet Primary Care*¹ outlines the transformative potential of advanced practice nurses (APNs) in primary care and calls for reforms in low-income and middle-income countries (LMICs) across four domains, comprising regulatory frameworks, education, service redesign, and public campaigns. Notably, the transformative potential of APNs is not restricted to LMICs, and several obstacles highlighted by Nashwan¹ that are hampering the implementation of APNs can also be found in high-income countries. Although APNs are an integral part of the health-care system in many Anglo-Saxon countries, others, such as Germany, are yet to include them.²

Advanced nursing roles in Germany are evolving, but slowly (figure). A lack of legislation and a restrictive scope of practice uphold barriers for nurses to work in advanced roles, as in several

LMICs. With the German history of primarily vocational training at nursing schools, Bachelors' degree programmes have only been adopted as part of the regular nursing education in the past 5 years. Despite several APN Masters' degree programmes being offered, a nationwide agreement for standardised curricula has not been achieved thus far. APNs are predominantly practising in hospital settings, thereby limiting their potential in primary care for individual-level and population-level health effects. Only a few small-scale pilot models have been implemented and evaluated in primary care, often without sustainable funding, implementation into routine care, or scale-up.³

Yet, innovation in primary care contexts has come out of times of emergency, such as the COVID-19 pandemic or climate-related disasters, or humanitarian challenges, such as large-scale immigration. Despite the absence of an enabling legal framework, models that have informally advanced the roles of nurses have emerged in Germany.^{2,4} These models

have the potential to strengthen crisis responses and improve the resilience of the health system. However, as there are no structures to integrate them into routine care, the models tend to cease once acute needs and demands have passed.

Transformative action across multiple levels is required for APNs in Germany to enhance primary care, support a resilient health system, and foster health equity. Competencies for APNs should be defined both on generic and specialised levels to address the needs of specific population groups or settings (eg, disaster nursing or refugee-health nursing).⁵ APN competencies should be consolidated into a national competency profile, alongside standardised APN education. Legal clarity on APN status and competencies, together with adequate remuneration and financing mechanisms that recognise APN services, is essential. Finally, there is a need for systematic evaluation to monitor the scaling up of the APN workforce, their effects on health services, team-based care, and health outcomes.



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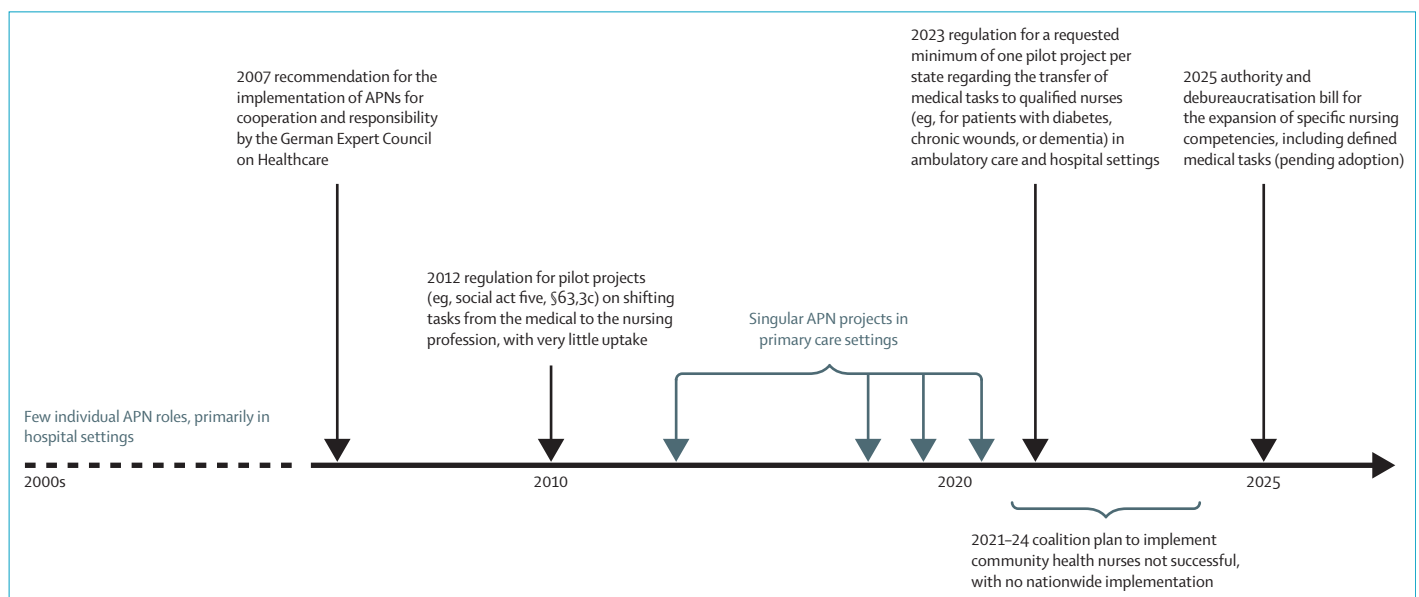


Figure: Developments towards APN implementation in Germany
APN=advanced practice nurse.

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